

Case Study 1 - Atari

Student submission

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Worksheet link

<https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/ac2579>

Grading link

<https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/ac2579>

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 0 declared AI use; 1 declared no AI use; policy v1

Game Overview

Game details

Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

Submitted response

Game: Berzerk
Dev: Alan McNeil
Publisher: Stern Electronics Inc.
Original Platform: Arcade
Genre: Multi-directional shooter.
Release:1980

I played the Atari version of the game that came out two years later in 1982, it is missing a few features of the original, mainly the voice feature and evil Otto.

History and industry

Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

Submitted response

The game was released in 1980 as a arcade game, which allowed it to catch the Golden Age of Arcade games, where the main way people can play games were in arcades on these big giant boxes. It's shooting feature wasn't the first as it was similar to many predecessor of the genre at the time like space invaders and Spacewars!. But is was know for it's fluid 8 dimensional movement and it's voice synthesizer feature, where voice lines would play while the player plays the game such as, "intruder alert! Intruder alert!", "Chicken! Fight like a robot!", "Got the intruder!", and "Coin detected in pocket!". Taunting the player or should I say ragebait the player to continue, also I researched it a little bit and I think this was a way for the developer to externalize his hate for computers. As the saying goes I'm not suffering we're suffering. Besides the voice lines the game also was one of the first games to introduce a endgame/late game feature, so the game can keep moving and anti-stagnation mechanic, in the for of evil otto. Evil Otto is a invincible enemy the spawns in as a smiley face that chases after the player, it anything it touches including enemies and when all the robots on the field dies otto speeds up to subtly suggest the player into the next stage with the threat of dying.

Contemporary comparison

Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

Submitted response

The game's controls are not the smoothest from the games of it's time, though that can definitely just be me playing it

on keyboard instead of a joystick, at the time a lot of games were introducing 2d movement, such as armor attack and rip off both released in the same year, but very few introduces the degree of control you have over your 8 directional movement, rip off and armor attack both have you control a vehicle that is already in constant motion, while Berzerk lets you fully control your movement. Berzerk also plays much more aggressive then similar games from the era, as the longer the game goes on the stronger Evil Otto gets, and compared to the more static map designs or the lack of designs from the era, Berzerk offers a large amount of random maps and stages that the player can play through. Also the map is also speeds up the game as touching the walls of the map kills you.

Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Core gameplay mechanics

Response prompt

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

Submitted response

The core gameplay of the game is the movement combined with shooting, the player constantly moves for better shooting positions and avoiding danger, while the shooting is the main way you can get rid of enemies and clear the level. Shooting also is a way for you to parry enemy attacks, as you can shoot the enemy projectile, but the fire rate of your gun is limited as only one of your projectiles can exist at the time, so if you shoot far away you would have a low fire rate but if you shoot a wall right in front of you, you can go crazy. The movement allows the player to avoid shots, avoid the enemies from touching you, and for you to get to the next level. Or if your me walk straight into the wall for the 5th time, also you move faster sideways then you do up and down which is stupid. So the overall game play if for the player to survive through movement, while clearing the level of enemies to earn points and advance to the next level.

Level design

Response prompt

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The game incentivizes the player to be aggressive. The map layout is anti life cause anything that touches a wall dies instantly, which includes the enemies who sometimes walk into them, so if you really want to you can clear a level without shooting a single shot. The enemies also makes sure that you are aggressive as they will kill you if they touch your or shoot you, so you better clear them out before they clear you out, the enemies can also kill each other if they shoot each other. The most important part that keeps the game mobile, Evil Otto, a evil smiley face that spawns 8 secs after you spawn, that will constantly charge towards you, forcing you to be mobile and kill enemies at the same time.

Graphic And Audio Design

Visual design

Response prompt

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The voices of the game, while I didn't experience it probably rage baited or enrages plenty of player. Even without the taunting voice lines I was getting frustrated play the game as the player can die to easily and sometimes the enemies spawned right on top of me, it felt as if everything was out to get me. So with the voices I can imagine that the game must have been frustrating and yet it baits you back again to beat it. The designs on the other had weren't anything spectacular, the basic same colored blocks that moved around with less visual clarity then space panic (a game released the same year).

Sound design

Response prompt

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

There really wasn't any music in the game that I played, and the sound effects were pretty average for the time though obnoxiously loud for me personally. Especially the death sound. But the voice lines as I explained before added a lot to the game's charm as a bad guy, like "yeah I bet you can't beat me!! you Chicken".

Narrative And Storytelling

Narrative and setting

Response prompt

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

Submitted response

The game was inspired by a book series called "Berserker" by Fred Saberhagen, where robots were hunting down organic lifeforms, which itself was probably inspired by the emergence of new technology at the time such as computers. The game itself simply does the concept of a humanoid player fighting a horde of robots out to get him.

Character development

Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

Submitted response

There isn't any character development to see, the sprite of the player and robot didn't change at all besides the color and the environment was random. Which I guess is reflected in the gameplay as you are just doing the same thing over and over again until you die.

Impact And Reception

Reception

Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback. Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

Submitted response

The game was actually received incredibly well despite being its creator's first game. Arcades especially in the west practically all had the game, taunting players to play with its unique voice feature. 15,000 machines were stocked in arcades in the US at the time of release and was ranked top 5 in the games at the time, even today it's still ranked in the top 100 games and still has players.

Industry and cultural impact

Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

Submitted response

The game was one of the first games to introduce a mechanic to prevent players from dragging on the game with Evil Otto, something that kept the game moving and its charming voice lines also inspired future games.

Reflection

Fun and experience

Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

Submitted response

It might just be me but the controls don't feel fluid on keyboard and took me a frustrating while to get used to, also why does the goddam all kill you??? I am trying to make precise peaking angle on robots and then I dies cause i got too close to a wall. Also the enemies are hard to kill cause if you can get a clean shot on them so can they. But what was interesting to me was that the fatal wall contact was the same for the enemy too, if they touch it they die as well.

Learning and research

Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

Submitted response

<https://www.anbmedia.com/news/2023/03/atari-acquisition-12-classic-arcade-properties-berzerk-frenzy/>

<https://www.newspapers.com/article/honolulu-star-bulletin-these-games-will/112582618/>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q7BFerxCB6E&t=511s>

Despite a games graphics if a game has charm it still can be popular, and it also showed how far games have come, cause at the time this was a top of the line game.

Researching wasn't as hard as I thought it would be for a game like this though, I might have gotten lucky with a news paper report post about the game that came out in 1981, that wrote about the sentiment of the game at the time.